CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

TILE SETTER IN THE AI ERA

Tile is forever — a good setter's work outlives the mortgage, and a bad one's mistakes get stared at in the shower for thirty years.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K for skilled setters, enterable in 1–6 months as a helper with no license required. The catch: knees, back and unforgiving geometry — tile shows every error, and the pay follows precision. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

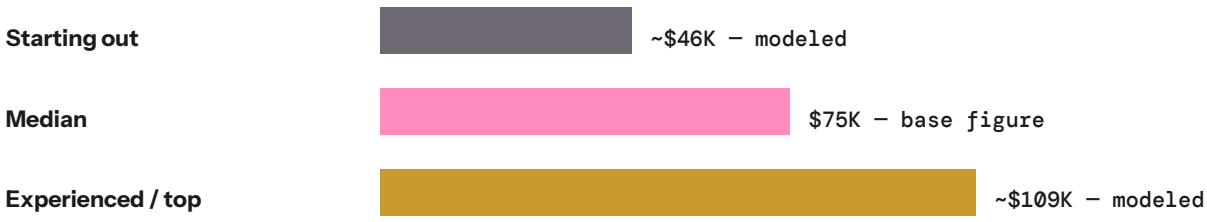
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: bathrooms, kitchens and floors keep getting tiled, and waterproof shower systems are skilled work homeowners fear to DIY badly.
- Bites because: the work is slow, physical and detail-obsessive — rushing tile produces permanent, visible regret.
- AI angle: minimal. Software helps layout and estimating; setting tile plumb, level and waterproof in crooked real rooms is pure hand craft.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Tile Setter is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A TILE SETTER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Prep substrates: backer board, membranes, waterproofing systems, and surfaces flat enough to deserve tile
- ✓ Lay out patterns — grids, herringbone, large-format — so cuts land where the eye won't punish them
- ✓ Cut and set tile with thinset, level and space it, then grout, seal and caulk the finished surface
- ✓ Build showers end-to-end: pans, slopes, drains, niches — the waterproofing is the real product

Think: a mosaic artist with a waterproofing engineer's responsibility — the beauty is the advertisement; the membrane underneath is the reputation.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Layout software, laser levels and wet-saw improvements make cutting faster. Nothing sets, levels and waterproofs a shower except the human kneeling in it.	Layout judgment in imperfect rooms, slope-to-drain feel, lippage you catch by hand, and waterproofing decisions that decide whether the bathroom lasts 3 years or 30.

⚠ **Your body is the business: knees and back take daily damage without protection and smart pacing. And helper pay starts modestly — the setter's money arrives with solo showers and a name for waterproof work done right.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Finished work you can photograph with genuine pride ✓ Premium niches: showers, large-format, stone, heated floors ✓ Solo and small-crew work suits independent temperaments	✗ Kneeling, lifting heavy tile and buckets, thinset on everything ✗ Slow, exact work — impatience is expensive ✗ A failed waterproofing job can mean tearing out your own masterpiece

Good fit? You're geometrically minded, patient, and quietly perfectionist; crooked lines bother you physically.
Bad fit? You rush, hate kneeling, or cut corners where nobody will see — in tile, everybody eventually sees.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — HELPER TO A TILE SETTER	DOOR B — FLOORING COMPANY / TRAINING ROUTE
Work under an experienced setter: mixing, carrying, grouting, cleaning, then cutting and setting. Tile crews and flooring companies hire helpers with no experience — in 1–6 months you'll handle real sections, and your education continues with every bathroom after.	Flooring retailers and installers run tile crews and sometimes formal training; manufacturer certification courses (for shower systems and membranes) add portable proof of waterproofing skill that homeowners and contractors both respect.

Smart move: Get certified on a major shower waterproofing system early. 'I build showers that don't leak, with a manufacturer-backed method' is a sentence that ends price negotiations. Where you land after: Helper → setter → shower/waterproofing specialist → own tile business or high-end remodel subcontractor.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET HIRED	LEARN PREP	LAYOUT AND	GROUTING AND	CERTIFY ON	TAKE YOUR

STEP 1 — Get hired as a helper

FREE · WEEK 1

- Apply to tile setters, flooring companies and remodelers; knees that can kneel and a back that can lift are the resume.
- Start gear right: knee pads, buckets, sponges, a decent trowel set as you earn.

STEP 2 — Learn prep and waterproofing

MONTHS 1-3

- Substrates, backer board, membranes and shower pans — the invisible 70% of the trade.
- Watch how pros flood-test and document their waterproofing; steal the habit.

STEP 3 — Layout and setting reps

MONTHS 2-6

- Grid math, pattern starts, cut placement — layout is where amateurs get exposed.
- Set floors, then walls, then your first supervised shower.

STEP 4 — Grouting and finish quality

ONGOING

- Grout joints, caulk lines and clean haze decide how 'professional' the job photographs.
- Learn stone and large-format handling — heavier, pricier, less forgiving, better paid.

STEP 5 — Certify on a shower system

COURSE · 1-2 DAYS

- Take a manufacturer certification for a foam/membrane shower system.
- Market the certification explicitly: leak-free showers with a system warranty.

STEP 6 — Take your own bathrooms

YEAR 1+

- Price full bathrooms, not hours — the package is where setter income jumps.
- Insure yourself; photograph every finished shower before the glass goes in.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: apply to two setters or flooring firms; knee pads bought before day one.

□ Days 1–30: mixing, grouting, cleaning — plus watching every layout decision your setter makes and asking why.

□ Days 31–60: first cutting and setting reps on floors; substrate and membrane training on real jobs.

□ Days 61–90: set wall tile under supervision; book a shower-system certification course.

□ Day 90: a helper turning into a setter, with waterproofing — the trade's money skill — in progress.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **WATERPROOF FIRST. BEAUTIFUL SECOND. BOTH ALWAYS.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.